

Critical theory



The neo-Marxist philosophy that emerged from the Frankfurt School may have seemed quite radical for its time, but had its roots in 19th-century German philosophical ideas. At its core was the idea of ‘critical theory’ (not to be confused with the theory of literary criticism that bears the same name), which was ultimately derived from Kant’s notion of providing a critique of existing ideas. More importantly, however, critical theory harked back to Hegel’s dialectic (see [Hegel’s dialectic](#)) and Marx’s exhortation to philosophers not to describe or explain the world, but to change it. Philosophers of the Frankfurt School sought to challenge ideologies, in particular those that imposed a world view designed to perpetuate the status

quo, such as capitalism and the form of communism that had evolved in the 20th century. A rigorous critique of the existing systems, using theories of sociology and psychology as well as philosophy, could be used to analyse political and social structures in order to produce a synthesis that could transform society for the better.